

A2-B1 · MAYA & EMMA ENGLISH

Why Do You Forget New Words?

You learn a new English word today, and three days later it is gone. Maya and Emma explain why this happens and share five easy tips, a speaking practice and a quick quiz.

Words in this episode

remember	to keep something in your mind	*I can't remember this word.*
forget	to not remember something	*I often forget new words.*
memory	the power to remember things	*She has a good memory.*
list	words or things written one under another	*I wrote a list of new words.*
notebook	a small book with empty pages for writing	*I write new words in my notebook.*
meaning	the idea that a word gives you	*What is the meaning of this word?*
sentence	a group of words with a full idea	*Please write one sentence with this word.*
borrow	to take something and give it back later	*Can I borrow your pen?*
useful	helping you to do something	*This is a very useful word.*
review	to look at something again so you remember it	*I review my words every evening.*
habit	something you do often, almost without thinking	*Reading every day is a good habit.*

connect	to join two things together	*I connect new words to my life.*
crowded	full of people	*The bus is crowded in the morning.*
generous	happy to give things to other people	*My grandmother is very generous.*
huge	very, very big	*An elephant is a huge animal.*

Say it out loud

1. I can't remember this word.
2. Can I borrow your pen, please?
3. The bus is crowded in the morning.
4. I review my words every evening.
5. This is a very useful word.
6. And now, the quiz. I will give you a meaning. You say the word. Then Maya will tell you the answer. Let's go. Question one. Which word means, to take something and give it back later?
7. Question two. Which word means, full of people?
8. Question three. Which word means, happy to give things to other people?
9. And question four. Which word means, to look at something again, so you remember it?

Transcript

Welcome

Emma: Hello everyone, and welcome back to our podcast! I'm Emma. This is the place where you can learn English with slow and clear conversations. Today's topic is a problem that every learner has. You learn a new word today. You feel happy. But three days later, the word is gone. Does this happen to you?

Maya: Hi Emma, and hi everyone! I'm Maya. Oh, this happens to me all the time. I see a word, and I think, I know this word! I learned it last week! But I can't remember what it means. It makes me a little crazy.

Emma: You are not alone, Maya. So today, we will talk about why we forget new words. Then we will share five easy tips to help the words stay in your head. And at the end, we have a speaking practice and a small quiz for you.

Maya: A quiz! I like that. Please stay with us until the end, and test yourself. You can listen to this episode many times. Every time you listen, you will remember a little more. Okay, Emma. Let's begin.

Why do we forget?

Maya: So, Emma, here is my first question. Why do we forget new words so quickly? Is my memory bad?

Emma: No, Maya. Your memory is not bad. Your brain is doing its job. Every day, your brain gets a lot of information. It can't keep everything. So it asks one simple question. Is this important? If the answer is no, the brain throws it away.

Maya: It is like cleaning a room. You keep the things that you use, and you throw away the old boxes.

Emma: Exactly. Now, think about a new English word. You see it one time, in a list or in a video. You don't use it. You don't see it again. So your brain thinks, this is not important. And it throws the word away, like an old box.

Maya: Poor little word. So the problem is not my memory. The problem is that I only meet the word one time.

Emma: Yes. Think about a person. If you meet someone one time at a party, you forget the name very fast. But if you see that person every day at work, you never forget the name. Words are the same. You need to meet a word many times, in many places.

Maya: That makes sense. And I think there is another problem. Many of us learn words in the wrong way. We write a long list. The English word is on the left, and our own language is on the right. Then we read the list again and again.

Emma: Oh, yes. The famous word list. It feels like hard work, so we think it is good. But a word in a list is alone. It has no story, no picture, and no feeling. It is very hard for the brain to keep it.

Emma's notebook

Maya: Emma, did you learn with word lists when you were a student?

Emma: I did! Let me tell you about my notebook. When I started to learn English, I bought a beautiful notebook. It was purple, of course. Every day, I wrote twenty new words in it. After three months, the notebook was full. I had almost two thousand words.

Maya: Two thousand words! That is amazing. I think your English was very good after that.

Emma: No! That is the sad part. One day, a friend asked me a simple question in English. I wanted to answer, but I couldn't find the words. All my words were sleeping in the notebook. They were not in my head, and they were not in my mouth.

Maya: Oh no. So what did you do with the notebook?

Emma: I opened it, and I tested myself. I covered the right side of the page, and I tried to remember the meaning of each word. From two thousand words, I remembered maybe two hundred. I felt terrible. Three months of work, and most of it was gone.

Maya: That is a sad story. But I think many listeners have the same notebook at home.

Emma: I think so too. But that day, I learned something important. Collecting words is not the same as learning words. I didn't need more words. I needed a better way. So I changed my way of learning, and now I want to share it with you.

Tip 1: Learn words in sentences

Maya: Great. Let's start with tip number one. What is it?

Emma: Tip number one. Don't learn a word alone. Learn it in a sentence. A sentence gives the word a home.

Maya: Can you give us an example?

Emma: Sure. Let's take the word borrow. You can write the word, and then the meaning in your language. That is the old way. Or you can write a sentence. Can I borrow your pen, please? Now you know the meaning. You also know how to use the word. And you have a sentence that you can say tomorrow.

Maya: I see. With the sentence, I get more than one thing. I get the word, the grammar, and the words that go together with it. Borrow a pen. Borrow a book. Borrow some money.

Emma: Yes! And it is even better when the sentence is about your own life. For example, I often borrow books from my sister. That is true for me. So my brain thinks, oh, this is about me. This is important. I will keep it.

Maya: So, a true sentence is better than a sentence from a book.

Emma: Much better. The sentence can be very simple, and it can even be a little funny. Funny sentences are easy to remember. For example, my cat borrows my chair every day, and she never gives it back.

Maya: Hey! That sounds like me. But the chair is very comfortable, Emma.

Tip 2: Use the word today

Emma: Okay, tip number two. Use the new word on the same day. Don't wait.

Maya: I like this one. When I learn a new word, I have a small rule. I try to use it three times before I go to bed.

Emma: Three times. How do you do that?

Maya: The first time, I say it out loud in a sentence. I say it to myself, in my room. The second time, I write it. Maybe in a message to a friend, or in a comment, or just in my notebook. And the third time, I try to use it when I talk with someone. If I have no one to talk to, I talk to my plants.

Emma: Your plants must speak very good English now.

Maya: They are almost perfect! But really, it works. When I say a word, write a word, and use a word in a real talk, I meet it three times in one day. So my brain understands that this word is useful.

Emma: That is a great rule. Listening and reading are good. But when you speak and write, you have to find the word in your head. That is hard work for the brain. And this hard work makes the memory strong.

Maya: It is like the gym. If the exercise is too easy, you don't get stronger.

Emma: Exactly. So don't just look at the word. Use it. Even one small sentence is enough.

Tip 3: Review at the right time

Maya: Now, tip number three. I think this one is very important. Review your words. But review them at the right time.

Emma: Yes. Many learners study a word one time, and then they never look at it again. Other learners read the same list ten times in one evening. Both ways are not very good.

Maya: So what is the right time?

Emma: Here is a simple plan. Look at the word again on the same evening. Then look at it the next day. Then after three days. Then after one week. And then after one month. Every time, you wait a little longer.

Maya: Let me say that again for our listeners. The same evening. The next day. After three days. After one week. After one month. That is five small meetings with the word.

Emma: Right. And each review is very short. It can be one minute. But here is the important part. Don't just read the word. Close your eyes, or cover the page, and try to remember it first. Ask yourself, what does this word mean? Can I make a sentence with it?

Maya: Oh, it is like a small test.

Emma: Yes, a small test for yourself. If you remember the word, great. If you don't remember it, that is okay too. Look at the answer, say the sentence out loud, and try again tomorrow. Forgetting is a normal part of learning.

Maya: I use small cards for this. On one side, I write the word. On the other side, I write my sentence. I keep the cards in my bag. When I wait for the bus, I take out five cards and I test myself. It takes two minutes.

Emma: That is a good habit. Small moments, many times. That is much better than two hours of study on Sunday night.

Tip 4: Connect the word to your life

Emma: Let's move to tip number four. Connect the new word to something. It can be a picture, a feeling, a place, or a person.

Maya: What do you mean?

Emma: Well, the brain loves pictures and feelings. It doesn't love empty words. So when you learn a word, make a little picture in your head. Let's take the word crowded. A crowded place is full of people. Now close your eyes. Think about a bus in the morning. There are so many people. You can't move. It is hot. That bus is crowded.

Maya: Oh, I can see it. I can even smell it. It is not nice!

Emma: Good! Now the word has a picture and a feeling. Next time you are on a full bus, say in your head, this bus is crowded. You will never forget that word.

Maya: I do something like this with people. When I learn a word about a person, I think about someone I know. For example, the word generous. A generous person likes to give things to others. My grandmother is generous. She always gives me too much food.

Emma: That is lovely. Now, every time you think of the word generous, you see your grandmother and a big plate of food.

Maya: And I feel hungry. You can also connect a word to a place. I put small papers on things in my house. On the mirror, on the fridge, and on the door. Every time I open the fridge, I read the word fridge. Now my whole kitchen speaks English.

Emma: I love that idea. Your house becomes your teacher.

Tip 5: Learn fewer words

Maya: And now, the last tip. Tip number five. This one may surprise you. Learn fewer words.

Emma: Fewer words? Maya, are you sure? Most people want to learn more words.

Maya: I'm sure. Remember your purple notebook. Twenty words a day, and two thousand words in three months. But you only remembered two hundred. Now think about a different plan. Only five words a day. But you learn them well. You write a sentence. You use them. You review them.

Emma: Five words a day. That is thirty-five words a week.

Maya: Yes. And in one year, that is more than one thousand eight hundred words. These are words that you really know, and that you can really use. That is a lot!

Emma: That is true. And five words is not scary. When I had twenty words every day, I felt tired before I started. Sometimes I did nothing. But five words? I can do that, even on a busy day.

Maya: Right. A small plan that you do every day is better than a big plan that you stop after one week. And please choose your words well. Don't learn every new word that you see. Ask yourself, do I need this word? Will I use it?

Emma: Good point. If you work in a hotel, learn words about hotels first. If you love cooking, learn words about food. Choose words that are useful for your own life. You can learn the name of a rare animal later.

Maya: Yes. I learned the word hedgehog five years ago. I have never used it. Not one time.

Emma: You just used it now, Maya.

Maya: Oh! Finally!

Three common mistakes

Emma: Before we make a word card, let's talk about three common mistakes. Mistake number one. Learning words that are too difficult.

Maya: Yes. Some learners open a newspaper, and they write down every word that they don't know. Long words, and rare words. But they still can't order a coffee in English. Please start with the words that people use every day. Easy words come first.

Emma: Mistake number two. Translating every word into your own language. Sometimes a translation helps, and that is fine. But a simple English meaning, or a small picture, is often better. Then your brain starts to think in English.

Maya: For example, for the word huge, I don't write a translation. I just write, very, very big. And I draw a small elephant next to it.

Emma: A small huge elephant. I like it. And mistake number three. Studying only when you feel like it. One day you study for three hours. Then you do nothing for two weeks. The brain doesn't like that. It likes a little bit, every day.

Maya: Yes. Ten minutes every day is better than three hours one time. I learn my five words in the morning, with my coffee. Coffee, and five words. Now it is automatic. When I smell coffee, I want to learn words.

Emma: That is funny, but it is also smart. When you connect a new habit to an old habit, it becomes easy. So choose your moment. With your coffee, on the bus, or before you sleep.

Your word card

Emma: Now let's put everything together. I want to show our listeners how to make a good word card. Maya, let's make one together. Please choose a word.

Maya: Okay. Let's take the word improve. It was in our last episode.

Emma: Good choice. Step one. Write the word on one side of the card. Step two. On the other side, don't write a long explanation. Write a short and simple meaning. For improve, we can write, to get better.

Maya: Step three. Write one true sentence about your life. My sentence is, I want to improve my English this year.

Emma: Very nice. Step four. Say the sentence out loud, two or three times. And step five. Put the card in your bag, and look at it again this evening.

Maya: So, one more time. The word. A simple meaning. A true sentence. Say it out loud. And review it later. It takes about two minutes for one word.

Emma: And if you don't like paper cards, you can do the same thing on your phone. The tool is not important. The steps are important.

Your turn: speaking practice

Maya: Okay, everyone. Now it's your turn to speak. Emma will say a sentence with one of today's words. After that, there is a short quiet time. Please say the sentence out loud. Are you ready? Here is sentence number one.

Emma: I can't remember this word.

Maya: Very good. Here is sentence number two.

Emma: Can I borrow your pen, please?

Maya: Nice. Here is sentence number three.

Emma: The bus is crowded in the morning.

Maya: Great job. Here is sentence number four.

Emma: I review my words every evening.

Maya: And here is the last one. Sentence number five.

Emma: This is a very useful word.

Maya: Well done! You just used five words from this episode. Your brain is already keeping them.

Quick quiz

Emma: And now, the quiz. I will give you a meaning. You say the word. Then Maya will tell you the answer. Let's go. Question one. Which word means, to take something and give it back later?

Maya: The answer is, borrow. Can I borrow your pen?

Emma: Question two. Which word means, full of people?

Maya: The answer is, crowded. The bus is crowded.

Emma: Question three. Which word means, happy to give things to other people?

Maya: The answer is, generous. My grandmother is generous.

Emma: And question four. Which word means, to look at something again, so you remember it?

Maya: The answer is, review. And that is what we just did!

Emma: How many answers did you know? If you knew two or more, that is a great start. Try this quiz again tomorrow, and see how many words you remember.

Review and goodbye

Maya: Let's quickly review our five tips. Tip one. Learn words in sentences, not alone. Tip two. Use the new word three times on the same day. Tip three. Review at the right time, and test yourself.

Emma: Tip four. Connect the word to a picture, a feeling, or a person. And tip five. Learn fewer words, but learn them well. Five good words a day is enough.

Maya: And don't be sad when you forget a word. Everybody forgets. I forget, and Emma forgets too. Just meet the word again, and say hello to it one more time.

Emma: We have a small job for you today. Choose one word from this episode. Write a true sentence about your life with it, and put it in the comments. We would love to read your sentences.

Maya: If this episode helped you, please like the video and subscribe to our channel. And share it with a friend who is learning English too.

Emma: Thank you for listening, everyone. Remember, small steps every day. See you in the next episode!

Maya: Bye bye, everyone. Take care!
